Himaayah Schools
ACADEMY

FREE GUIDE

وَقُل رَّبِّ زِدْنِي عِلْمًا

"And say: My Lord, increase me in knowledge." (Ṭā Hā 20:114)

JAMB Islamic Studies

A UTME study guide: the Qur'an, the Ḥadīth, tawḥīd, fiqh, the sīrah and Islām in West Africa, with a practice test.

بِسْمِ اللَّهِ الرَّحْمٰنِ الرَّحِيمِ

Before you begin

Islamic Studies in the UTME covers the Qur'an, the Ḥadīth, tawḥīd, fiqh, the sīrah and Islamic history, including the spread of Islām in West Africa. A Madrasah student already knows much of it; the task is to learn it in the way the exam asks, with dates, names and definitions. This guide gives you the syllabus in six areas, the key facts, sample questions explained, the traps to avoid, an 8-week plan and a practice test.

The UTME at a glance	
Subjects	Use of English and three subjects for your course. Islamic Studies is accepted for law, Islamic studies, Arabic, education and many arts and social science courses.
Questions	Use of English 60; each other subject 40; 180 questions in all, on computer (CBT).
Time	About two hours for all four papers, so roughly 40 seconds a question. You move freely between subjects.
Marking	Each subject is scored out of 100, for a total out of 400. There is no negative marking: never leave a question blank.

Check the official details

Exam rules and syllabuses can change from year to year. Always check the current JAMB brochure and the official Islamic Studies syllabus on the JAMB website or e-facility portal, and follow them where they differ from this guide.

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Part 1 The syllabus at a glance

Study from the **JAMB syllabus**, not only from your school notes: every UTME question comes from a topic on it. The topics fall into these areas:

Area	Topics
The Qur'an	Revelation, its stages and the first and last revelations; compilation under Abū Bakr and standardisation under ʿUthmān; Makkan and Madinan sūrahs; the sciences of the Qur'an (tajwīd, tafsīr, asbāb an-nuzūl, abrogation); selected sūrahs and their lessons
The Ḥadīth	Definition of ḥadīth and sunnah; the isnād and matn; classification (ṣaḥīḥ, ḥasan, ḍaʿīf); compilation; the Muwaṭṭaʾ and the six books; selected aḥādīth, e.g. from an-Nawawī's Forty
Tawḥīd	The articles of faith; the oneness of Allah; shirk and its forms; prophethood; the Last Day; the decree
Fiqh	Sources of the Sharīʿah (Qur'an, Sunnah, ijmāʿ, qiyās); the schools of law; ṭahārah, ṣalāh, zakāh, ṣawm and Ḥajj; marriage, divorce and ʿiddah; inheritance; dietary laws; Islamic economic principles
Sīrah and early Islamic history	The life of the Prophet ﷺ in Makkah and Madinah; the Hijrah; major battles; the Treaty of al-Ḥudaybiyah; the Opening of Makkah; the four rightly guided caliphs
Islām in West Africa and moral teachings	The coming of Islām to West Africa; Kanem-Borno, Mali, Songhai and Hausaland; the Sokoto Caliphate and Shehu ʿUthmān Dan Fodio; Islamic morals and the Muslim personality

Fiqh, the Qur'an and history together produce most questions. Learn dates and names in tables, and know the evidence (verse or ḥadīth) for the main rulings.

Part 2 Key facts to know

The Qur'an and the Ḥadīth

Fact	Detail
First revelation	Al-ʿAlaq 96:1–5, in the cave of Ḥirāʾ, about 610 CE, when the Prophet ﷺ was forty
Period of revelation	About 23 years: 13 in Makkah and 10 in Madinah
Sūrahs and verses	114 sūrahs; 6,236 verses in the common (Kufan) count; 30 ajzāʾ
Compilation	Gathered into one copy under Abū Bakr by Zayd ibn Thābit, after the Battle of al-Yamāmah; standard copies sent to the provinces under ʿUthmān
Ḥadīth terms	Isnād: chain of narrators. Matn: the text. Ṣaḥīḥ: sound. Ḥasan: good. Ḍaʿīf: weak. Mutawātir: narrated by so many that error is impossible
The six books	Al-Bukhārī, Muslim, Abū Dāwūd, at-Tirmidhī, an-Nasāʾī and Ibn Mājah. Earlier: the Muwaṭṭaʾ of Imām Mālik

Fiqh

Topic	Key facts
Sources of law	Qur'an, Sunnah, ijmāʿ (consensus) and qiyās (analogy); also istiḥsān, maṣlaḥah and ʿurf in some schools
The four Sunnī schools	Ḥanafī (Abū Ḥanīfah), Mālikī (Mālik ibn Anas), Shāfiʿī (ash-Shāfiʿī), Ḥanbalī (Aḥmad ibn Ḥanbal). The Mālikī school is followed across West Africa
Five rulings (al-aḥkām al-khamsah)	Wājib (obligatory), mandūb (recommended), mubāḥ (permitted), makrūh (disliked), ḥarām (forbidden)
Zakāh	Rate 2.5% on money and trade goods after a lunar year; 10% or 5% on crops; eight recipients (at-Tawbah 9:60)
Inheritance (an-Nisāʾ 4:11–12)	Husband: ½ (no children), ¼ (with children). Wife: ¼ (no children), ⅛ (with children). A son takes twice the share of a daughter. One daughter alone: ½
ʿIddah	Divorce: three menstrual cycles (al-Baqarah 2:228). Widow: four months and ten days (2:234). Pregnant: until delivery (aṭ-Ṭalāq 65:4)

Islām in West Africa

Event	Date or detail
Kanem: first Muslim ruler, Mai Humai (Hume) Jilmi	Late 11th century
Mali: Mansa Mūsā's famous pilgrimage to Makkah	1324
Songhai: Askia Muḥammad	Late 15th and early 16th centuries; Timbuktu a centre of learning
Shehu ʿUthmān Dan Fodio begins his jihād	1804
Sokoto founded as capital of the Caliphate (Muḥammad Bello)	About 1809
Scholars of the Caliphate	Shehu ʿUthmān, ʿAbdullāh Dan Fodio, Muḥammad Bello, Nana Asmāʾ

Part 3 Sample questions, explained

Example 1. The first verses of the Qur'an to be revealed are from Sūrat:
→ The first revelation was al-ʿAlaq 96:1–5 in the cave of Ḥirāʾ (al-Bukhārī, 3).
Answer: Al-ʿAlaq

Example 2. Who was charged by Abū Bakr with compiling the Qur'an into one copy?
→ Zayd ibn Thābit, a scribe of revelation, gathered it from writings and memories (al-Bukhārī, 4986).
Answer: Zayd ibn Thābit

Example 3. The chain of narrators of a ḥadīth is called the:
→ Isnād is the chain; matn is the text.
Answer: Isnād

Example 4. Which source of Islamic law means the consensus of the scholars?
→ Ijmāʿ is consensus; qiyās is analogy.
Answer: Ijmāʿ

Example 5. A wife whose husband died leaving children inherits:
→ With children, the wife's share is one eighth (an-Nisāʾ 4:12).
Answer: One eighth

Example 6. The ʿiddah of a widow who is not pregnant is:
→ Four months and ten days (al-Baqarah 2:234).
Answer: Four months and ten days

Example 7. The jihād of Shehu ʿUthmān Dan Fodio began in:
→ It began in 1804 in Gobir and led to the Sokoto Caliphate.
Answer: 1804

Example 8. The school of law followed by most Muslims in West Africa is the:
→ West Africa has followed the Mālikī school for centuries.
Answer: Mālikī school

Example 9. The treaty that Allah called "a clear victory" is the Treaty of:
→ Sūrat al-Fatḥ (48:1) was revealed about al-Ḥudaybiyah, 6 AH.
Answer: Al-Ḥudaybiyah

Part 4 Traps that cost marks

Trap	What to do
Mixing up the compilations	Abū Bakr: gathered into one copy. ʿUthmān: standard copies sent to the provinces.
Isnād versus matn	Isnād is the chain; matn is the text.
Inheritance shares	Learn the husband and wife shares with and without children in a table.
Dates of the battles	Badr 2 AH, Uḥud 3 AH, the Trench 5 AH, al-Ḥudaybiyah 6 AH, the Opening of Makkah 8 AH.
Arabic terms spelled differently	The exam may spell terms without diacritics (Hadith, Sallah, Zakat). Recognise the word, whatever the spelling.
Using a school other than the one asked about	Where the question asks for a general ruling, give the ruling agreed upon; where it names a school, answer for that school.

Part 5 An 8-week plan

Start at least eight weeks before the exam. Each week: learn the topics, make short notes and solve past questions under time. Keep one day a week for revision.

Week	Focus	Practice
1	The Qur’an: revelation, compilation, sciences	Key facts table; 30 questions
2	Selected sūrahs and their lessons	Read each with its meaning
3	The Ḥadīth: terms, compilation, selected aḥādīth	Past questions
4	Tawḥīd and the articles of faith	Definitions and evidence
5	Fiqh of worship: ṭahārah, ṣalāh, zakāh, ṣawm, Ḥajj	Rulings and evidence
6	Family law, inheritance and economic principles	Shares table; calculations
7	Sīrah, the caliphs and Islām in West Africa	Dates drill
8	Full revision and mock exams	Two full timed papers

Exam-day reminders

Read every option before choosing. Eliminate the clearly wrong ones first.

Do not spend more than a minute on one question: flag it and come back.

Answer every question; there is no penalty for a wrong answer.

Check that your answers are saved before you submit, and keep an eye on the clock for all four subjects.

Test Practice test

Give yourself 10 minutes for these 15 questions, as in the real exam. The answers follow.

1. The Qur’an was revealed over a period of about:

a) 10 years b) 23 years c) 40 years d) 13 years

2. How many sūrahs are in the Qur’an?

a) 114 b) 30 c) 99 d) 120

3. The text of a ḥadīth, as opposed to its chain, is the:

a) Isnād b) Rāwī c) Matn d) Sanad

4. Which of these is NOT one of the six books of ḥadīth?

a) Sunan Abī Dāwūd b) Jāmiʿ at-Tirmidhī c) Sunan an-Nasāʾī d) Tafsīr Ibn Kathīr

5. Qiyās means:

a) Consensus b) Analogy c) Custom d) Public interest

6. The founder of the Mālikī school was:

a) Mālik ibn Anas b) Abū Ḥanīfah c) Aḥmad ibn Ḥanbal d) Al-Bukhārī

7. The rate of zakāh on money held for a year is:

a) 10% b) 5% c) 2.5% d) 20%

8. A husband whose wife died leaving no children inherits:

a) ¼ b) ⅛ c) ⅓ d) ½

9. The ʿiddah of a divorced woman who menstruates is:

a) Three menstrual cycles b) Four months and ten days c) One month d) Forty days

10. The Battle of Badr took place in:

a) 1 AH b) 2 AH c) 3 AH d) 5 AH

11. Mansa Mūsā of Mali made his famous pilgrimage in:

a) 1804 b) 1100 c) 1324 d) 1500

12. The Sokoto Caliphate grew out of the jihād of:

a) Askia Muḥammad b) Shehu ʿUthmān Dan Fodio c) Mai Idrīs Alooma d) Al-Kānemī

13. Something the Sharīʿah forbids is:

a) Makrūh b) Mubāḥ c) Mandūb d) Ḥarām

14. Who gathered the Qur’an into one copy after al-Yamāmah?

a) Zayd ibn Thābit, under Abū Bakr b) ʿAlī, under ʿUthmān c) Ibn Masʿūd, under ʿUmar d) Muʿāwiyah

15. The last of the four rightly guided caliphs was:

a) Abū Bakr b) ʿUmar c) ʿUthmān d) ʿAlī

No.	Answer	No.	Answer
1	b) 23 years	9	a) Three menstrual cycles
2	a) 114	10	b) 2 AH
3	c) Matn	11	c) 1324
4	d) Tafsīr Ibn Kathīr	12	b) Shehu ʿUthmān Dan Fodio
5	b) Analogy	13	d) Ḥarām
6	a) Mālik ibn Anas	14	a) Zayd ibn Thābit
7	c) 2.5%	15	d) ʿAlī
8	d) ½		

Recommended textbooks

- **Islamic Studies for Senior Secondary Schools** (the IRS textbook your school uses).
- Our free Madrasah guides: **The Four Imams**, **The Battles of the Prophet ﷺ**, **The Makkan Years**, **The Fiqh of Zakāh** and **The Forty Ḥadīth**.
- Other texts listed in the current JAMB Islamic Studies syllabus.
- **Past questions**: solve at least the last ten years' UTME Islamic Studies questions, timing yourself, and study every one you get wrong.

Prepare with the Himaayah Academy

Live UTME, Post-UTME and O-Level classes with a personal mentor, daily tasks, weekly mock exams, CBT practice and a leaderboard, all online.

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وَمَا تَوْفِيقِي إِلَّا بِاللَّهِ

"And my success is only through Allah." (Hūd 11:88)

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What you learned in the Madrasah, for the exam.

This free guide from the Himaayah Academy helps UTME candidates prepare for Islamic Studies with the facts, dates and definitions the exam asks about.

- The Islamic Studies syllabus in six areas
- The Qur'an and the Ḥadīth: key facts
- Fiqh, inheritance shares and ʿiddah
- Islām in West Africa
- An 8-week plan and a 15-question practice test

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